

MYTHS

The Legends of Archimedes Go On

Archimedes was a brilliant Greek mathematician, scientist, and inventor who lived in Syracuse, Sicily. King Hiero often asked him to solve difficult problems. One day, the king wanted to know if his crown was made of pure gold without melting it. While taking a bath, Archimedes noticed that water overflowed when he stepped into the tub. This inspired him to discover a way to test the crown, leading him to shout, "Eureka!" He proved that the crown was not made of pure gold and discovered the principle of water displacement, now known as the Archimedes Principle.

Archimedes also demonstrated how a small force could move a heavy ship by using a system of pulleys. His discoveries led to the development of important machines and scientific principles. He also improved the value of pi, invented the Archimedean screw for lifting water, and created powerful war machines like the catapult. His inventions and discoveries continue to influence science and mathematics today.

Pandora's Box

Long ago, the king of the gods, Zeus, wanted to punish humans for receiving fire from Prometheus. He ordered the creation of Pandora, the first woman, and gave her a beautiful jar. Zeus warned her never to open it. Pandora became curious about what was inside. One day, she opened the jar, and terrible things such as sickness, sadness, fear, and anger escaped into the world. Frightened, she quickly closed the jar, but only one thing remained inside—Hope. Hope later came out to comfort people, reminding them that even during difficult times, there is always hope.

Echo and Narcissus

Echo was a kind mountain nymph who loved to talk. Because she distracted the goddess Hera, she was punished and could only repeat the last words spoken by others. One day,

Echo fell in love with a handsome young man named Narcissus. However, Narcissus admired only himself and rejected everyone who loved him. As punishment for his pride, he fell in love with his own reflection in a pool of water. Unable to leave it, he remained there until he died, and a beautiful flower grew in his place. Echo's voice continued to be heard in the mountains.

King Midas and the Golden Touch

King Midas loved gold more than anything. One day, the god Dionysus granted him one wish. Midas wished that everything he touched would turn into gold. At first, he was delighted as trees, furniture, and stones became gold. But when he touched his food and water, they also turned to gold, making it impossible to eat or drink. Even his beloved daughter turned into a golden statue when he hugged her. Realizing his mistake, Midas begged the god to remove the gift. Dionysus told him to wash in a river, and the golden touch disappeared.

Daedalus and Icarus

Daedalus was a skilled inventor who built wings from feathers and wax for himself and his son, Icarus, so they could escape from an island. Before they flew, Daedalus warned Icarus not to fly too close to the sun or too close to the sea.

Excited by flying, Icarus ignored his father's warning and soared higher and higher. The sun melted the wax holding his wings together, and he fell into the sea. Daedalus safely reached land but sadly lost his son because he did not listen.

Demeter and Persephone

Persephone, the daughter of the harvest goddess Demeter, was taken to the underworld by Hades. Demeter became so sad that plants stopped growing, and the world became cold and barren. Zeus ordered Hades to let Persephone return to her mother. However, because Persephone had eaten a few pomegranate seeds in the underworld, she had to spend part of each year with Hades. Whenever Persephone returned to Demeter, flowers bloomed and crops grew. When she went back to the underworld, the plants withered.

The Blessings of the Banyan Tree

A Myth Adapted by the Author

In a small village, there stood an ancient banyan tree believed to be a source of blessings. The villagers often visited the tree to give thanks for their good fortune, knowing that the tree had the power to bring prosperity to those who expressed their gratitude sincerely. The tree was a symbol of hope and abundance, its roots deep and branches wide, providing shade and shelter to all who sought it.

One year, a terrible drought struck the village. The once fertile fields turned barren, and the river that flowed through the village dried up.

Food and water became scarce, and the villagers grew desperate. Despite their hardships, they gathered around the banyan tree offering prayers and gratitude for any small blessings they still had.

Among them was a young girl named Mira, who always expressed her gratitude eloquently. Mira's family had taught her the importance of being thankful, even in difficult times.

She approached the tree and said, "Thank you, dear banyan tree for the strength to endure and the hope to see another day. We are grateful for the little we have and for the promise of better times."

Moved by the villagers' gratitude, the banyan tree's roots reached deep into the earth, searching for water. After days of effort, the roots found a hidden underground spring. Water began to flow, revitalizing the village.

Years passed, and the banyan tree grew even more majestic, its branches spreading wide to provide shelter and comfort. The villagers continued to gather beneath its shade, sharing stories of gratitude and blessings. The banyan tree became a symbol of their enduring faith and the power of thankfulness.

Mira, now an elder in the village, reflected on the lessons she had learned. She realized that gratitude was not just about the words they spoke but also about the actions they took to receive and create a legacy of kindness and generosity.

The Trojan Horse

Long ago, the Greeks and the Trojans fought a war for ten years. The Greeks wanted to rescue Helen, the queen of Sparta, who had been taken to the city of Troy. However, Troy was protected by strong, high walls that the Greek army could not break through.

One day, the clever Greek general Odysseus came up with a plan. He told the Greeks to build a giant wooden horse that was hollow inside. A group of brave Greek soldiers hid inside the horse while the rest of the army pretended to sail away, making it seem as if they had given up the war.

When the Trojans saw that the Greeks were gone, they believed they had won. They found the large wooden horse outside the city gates and thought it was a peace offering. They happily pulled the horse into the city and celebrated their victory.

That night, after everyone in Troy had fallen asleep, the Greek soldiers climbed out of the wooden horse. They quietly opened the city gates, allowing the rest of the Greek army, who had secretly returned, to enter the city. The Greeks surprised the Trojans and captured Troy, ending the long war.

Sif's Golden Hair

Loki, the mischievous brother of Odin, loved causing trouble wherever he went. One day, he saw Sif, the wife of Thor, sleeping peacefully. Sif was famous for her long, beautiful golden hair, which she treasured. While she slept, Loki secretly cut off all her hair just for fun.

When Sif woke up and discovered what had happened, she cried because she loved her golden hair and feared that Thor would be angry. When Thor found out that Loki was responsible, he became furious. He confronted Loki and threatened to punish him unless he found a way to replace Sif's hair. Frightened, Loki promised to make things right.

To keep his promise, Loki traveled to the underground world of the skilled elves. He asked them to create new hair for Sif using pure gold. The elves carefully crafted golden strands that were soft, beautiful, and looked just like real hair.

Loki returned to Asgard and placed the golden hair on Sif's head. To everyone's amazement, the golden hair magically grew and became part of her, looking even more beautiful than before. Sif was happy again, and Thor forgave Loki for his mischief.

Odysseus and the Cyclops

After the Trojan War, Odysseus and his men sailed home. During their journey, they landed on an island that was home to the Cyclopes, a race of giant one-eyed creatures. They entered a large cave, ate some food they found there, and waited, not knowing it belonged to a Cyclops named Polyphemus.

When Polyphemus returned, he trapped Odysseus and his men inside the cave by rolling a huge stone over the entrance. The giant was cruel and began eating two of Odysseus' men every day. Since only the Cyclops was strong enough to move the stone, Odysseus knew he had to think of a clever way to escape.

Odysseus came up with a plan. He offered Polyphemus strong wine, which made the giant fall into a deep sleep. Before the Cyclops fell asleep, he asked Odysseus for his name. Odysseus cleverly replied, "My name is No Man."

While Polyphemus slept, Odysseus and his remaining men sharpened a large wooden stake,

heated it in the fire, and drove it into the Cyclops' only eye. The giant cried out in pain and called for help. When the other Cyclopes asked who had hurt him, he answered, "No Man!" Thinking no one had attacked him, they left without helping.

The next morning, the blind Cyclops let his sheep out to graze. To escape, Odysseus tied each of his men underneath the sheep, while he held onto the last sheep himself. Polyphemus only felt the sheep's backs, so he did not notice the men hiding underneath. In this way, Odysseus and his crew escaped safely.

As they sailed away, Odysseus proudly shouted his real name to Polyphemus, revealing who had tricked him. The story shows that intelligence, courage, and quick thinking can help overcome great danger, but it also reminds us that pride can sometimes lead to trouble.

Narcissus

Long ago in Ancient Greece, a river god named Cephissus and his wife Liriope had a son named Narcissus. He grew up to be a very handsome and strong young man. Before he was born, a wise soothsayer named Teiresias predicted that Narcissus would live a long life only if he never saw his own reflection. To protect him, his mother hid all the mirrors and covered the windows in their home.

As Narcissus grew older, he met a kind nymph named Echo, who fell deeply in love with him. However, Echo had been cursed by the goddess Hera. Because of the curse, she could only repeat the last words spoken by others and could not express her true feelings. When Narcissus asked if she liked him, Echo could only repeat his last words. Narcissus misunderstood her and thought she only cared about herself, so he turned away. Heartbroken, Echo left in sadness.

Later, Narcissus went to a quiet river to be alone. As he looked into the still water, he saw his own reflection for the first time. Not realizing it was himself, he believed he was looking at another beautiful person. He became so fascinated by the image that he could not look away.

The prophecy of Teiresias came true. Narcissus remained by the river, staring at his reflection for so long that the gods transformed him into a beautiful flower. That flower became known as the narcissus, which still grows in the same place according to the myth.

The Sky Woman

Long ago, the world was covered with water, and there was no sun, moon, or stars. High above the earth lived the Great Spirit and his daughter, Sky Woman. One day, the Great Spirit sent Sky Woman down to the world below. As she fell, the water animals worked together to help her. After many attempts, the muskrat brought up a small amount of earth from beneath the water. The animals placed it on the back of a giant turtle, where it grew into a large land for Sky Woman to live on.

Sky Woman later gave birth to twin sons known as the Good Spirit and the Evil Spirit. After her death, the Good Spirit created the sun, moon, stars, plants, animals, rivers, and the first human. The Evil Spirit tried to ruin his brother's creations by making dangerous animals, poisonous plants, and other harmful things.

The two brothers eventually fought, and the Good Spirit defeated the Evil Spirit and banished him underground. Even so, the Evil Spirit's influence remained in the world.